Congress in 2017, also had the backing of several 'new entrants' into the party. That the BJP plumped for Sawant is an indication that the party does not want to hurt its loyalists. Union minister Narendra Tomar, the BJP central observer who oversaw Sawant's selection as legislative party leader, told reporters categorically that he would be CM for the next five years.

Sawant will have to maintain a fine balance among the various communities while allocating ministerial portfolios. Two Catholics, veterans Mauvin Godinho and Atanasio Monserrate, could get plum departments. Apart from that, Rohan Khaunte, the only Saraswat MLA, is also likely to become a minister. The community, which makes up 7 per cent of Goa's population, is highly influential in business and social circles. They have been upset with the BJP ever since the party denied Utpal Parrikar, son of the late CM Manohar Parrikar, a ticket in his father's constituency, Panaji. Khaunte only joined the BJP in January but may still get a portfolio. The BJP needs him as a bridge between the party and the Saraswats.

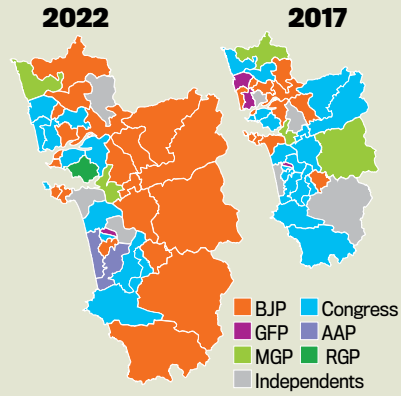
Sawant says his focus will be to make Goa self-reliant on various fronts, and this includes a roadmap to end the state's dependency on Maharashtra and Karnataka for essential commodities. The plan looks attractive but implementation may be a herculean task. Goa's economy has been in a shambles following the March 2018 Supreme Court ban on iron ore mining and tourism, the other mainstay, collapsing with the pandemic too. The SC has made it clear that mining can be resumed only after fresh auctions of the mining leases (the last were issued in the 1980s). Local mining firms have strongly opposed the idea, saying the mining giants from outside will take over the state's natural resources. Goa has been losing annual revenue to the tune of Rs 6,000 crore since mining came to a halt. The number is significant, considering the fragile nature of Goa's finances—the 2021-22 budget was Rs 25,000 crore, and the state has an almost equal amount in debt.

The mining sector used to provide direct and indirect employment to around 250,000 people. Ambar Timblo, president of the Goa Mineral Ore Exporters' Association, is still hopeful. "The central law does provide necessary solutions to bypass the auction process," he points out. A senior BJP leader, however, differs. "What's the harm if outsiders extract Goa's iron ore? Finally, they will be generating revenue," he says. "The government's only concern should be jobs for the locals. There will be no issues if the locals are happy."

There's potential for conflict here. The BJP may be forced to take into account "local sentiments", an outcome of the emergence of the Revolutionary Goan Party (RGP) as a strong regional force. With 9.7 per cent votes, the RGP made its presence felt in its first-ever election. A strong advocate of 'Goa for Goans', the RGP has found a base in 10 of the state's 40 constituencies. If it expands its base in north Goa, a bastion of the BJP, the ruling party will be in trouble. "The RGP can't be ignored, it has energised the youth. I see it emerging as the new Congress in Goa," says political commentator Rajendra Desai. With victory in nine of 20 seats, the BJP did quite well in its "weak region", south Goa. The Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) is now a force here, winning two seats and making inroads in another five.

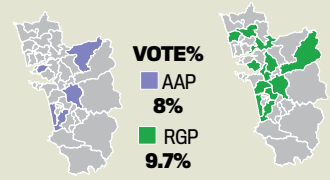
The BJP was able to beat the anti-incumbency of 10 years because of strong backing from the OBCs (Other Backward Classes), its traditional supporters. With Catholics and Saraswats still keeping their distance, the BJP needs to consolidate its base among the OBCs. If the MGP—a party of dominant castes opposed to the BJP before the polls—is allowed to join the government, the OBCs will be hurt. But the two MGP MLAs are the BJP leadership's insurance against rebellion breaking out in the party. "We have the three Independents and MGP's two MLAs, which takes our numbers to 25, a comfortable majority," says Devendra Fadnavis, the BJP's Goa in-charge. This is a counter-strategy to secure the government if Rane raises a flag of revolt. Seems like a prelude for turbulent political scenes in the future. ■

THE GOA MOSAIC



THE CHALLENGERS...

The Revolutionary Goan Party (RGP) and Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) secured more than 3,000 votes in certain constituencies, enough to spoil anyone's chances in Goa



...AND THE CHALLENGES

- **Iron ore mining:** The state's economy has been badly hit since mining came to a halt in March 2018. The government will have to follow the Supreme Court's ruling on auctioning of minefields
- **Boost to tourism:** The backbone of the state economy (after mining) is going through its worst phase. A new tourism policy has been announced, implementation is key now
- **Mopa airport:** Goa's second airport at Mopa has already missed its original deadline by two years. This airport is likely to be a game-changer for the north Goa region
- **Recruitment:** Sawant faced faced allegations of corruption, nepotism and regionalism in recruitments for state jobs in the first term. The new government must bring transparency in recruitment processes
- **Green concerns:** The south Goa region is battling the government over destruction of the environment for development projects. An amicable solution must be found